

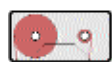
30 Minutes Expert

All the music you can't leave behind

Here you are, the proud owner of a newfangled portable MP3 player, but alas! All your favourite music is trapped inside old Audiocassettes. Or maybe the convenience of having your entire music collection of tapes in a compressed MP3 audio format is just too tempting. Whichever way, converting that old ABBA cassette into an MP3 memorial is just a hop, skip and jump away.

What you will need

- A cassette player. The sound quality achieved will depend on the capability of the chosen player.
- A soundcard with a Line In jack inside your computer.
- The MUSICMATCH Jukebox software, featured in the Digit Mindware CD, September 2002. A free trial can be downloaded from www.musicmatch.com
- About 1 MB of free hard disk space for every minute of music that is to be recorded.



Getting it together

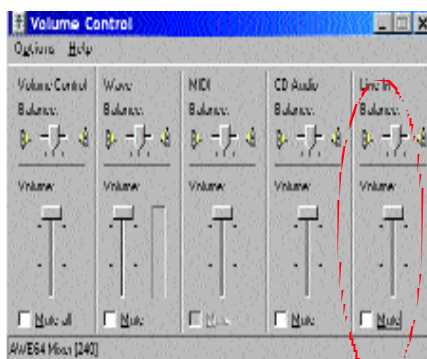
Connect your cassette player to the soundcard in your computer. This can be done in two ways: if the player has a Line Out port, use a stereo to RCA cable (the one with a red and a white connector at one end and a single-pin stereo jack at the other) to connect it to your computer. If the Line Out port is absent, use the headphone port to connect it to the card—a simple cable with 1/8-inch headphone plugs on both ends will do just fine. You can buy this cable from an electronic shop or if you are feeling adventurous, you can make one yourself. All you need to do is locate two pairs of old headphones. It is important that at least one of them has a good wire. Cut off the plugs from both the pairs and extract a length of wire from one of them. Connect the two plugs with the

wire and voila! You have the required cable! Next, ensure that the bass, treble and loudness levels on the player are all set to zero—this is called normalisation and it will give you the best quality audio by minimising the sound distortion.



Set the controls

Double-click on the little speaker icon next to the clock on the lower right of your screen to bring up the Volume Control. You need to ascertain two things: that the Line In control is not muted and that the volume level for the same is not set to zero. If the speaker icon is missing on your system, go to **Start > Settings > Control Panel > Multimedia Properties**. Here, select the 'Show volume control on the taskbar' checkbox. Note that the soundcard must be correctly installed for this.



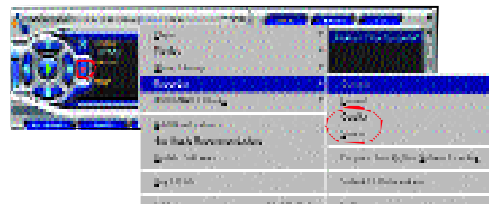
Make sure that the Line In column is not muted and its volume is not set to zero

Set the player's volume level to about one-third the power level and press Play. If the setup is correct, you will hear the music flowing from your PC speakers. If you do not hear any sound, check the Volume Control settings and make sure that the cable is connected firmly to the Line In port of the soundcard.



Sound check

Now that you have connected your player to the computer and prepared your system, do a test run to ensure that everything is working as it should. In MUSICMATCH Jukebox, go to **Options > Recorder > Source** and select Line In.



The two options to look for are highlighted above. Also note the Record button

Then, go to **Options > Recorder > Quality** and select MP3 (128 kbps). Press Play on the cassette deck and click on the Record button of the Jukebox. Wait until the indicator at the bottom of the MUSICMATCH window shows around 30 seconds of audio, and then press Stop on the software.

Play the created test file (find it in your MUSICMATCH Rips directory) to get a handle on the quality of the recording. If the output of the recorded file is too soft, play around with the volume level on the player, and the Volume Control on the taskbar till you get the clearest sounds possible. Repeat this step to get 30-second test snippets of the cassette, until you are satisfied with the quality of recording.



For the record

Once you are satisfied with the sound quality, repeat the process outlined under 'Sound check', only this time, continue for the duration of the cassette. Now you don't have to worry about those squeaky tapes!

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